



would accept this since it would turn him into a completely toothless President but he may agree to subject his powers to oversight from the Supreme Court before using them. On their part, Musharraf's coalition—especially the King's Party PML(Q)—are apprehensive of being marginalised should a genuinely popular party such as PPP come on board with Musharraf. Having lost ground because of Musharraf's plummeting approval ratings and Sharif's resurgence, they do not want any such perception to further ruin their chances in the elections.

Bhutto would also like Musharraf's ban on prime ministers serving more than two terms to go, which would allow her—and Sharif—to contend for the top government slot again. This is something the ruling PML(Q) finds anathema, in particular, since it would

★ Musharraf's popularity plummeted following his futile attempt to sack the chief justice in March. ★



send out the message that it has been dumped for PPP, a scary prospect for it in the elections. PML(Q) leader Chaudhry Shujaat was quoted grumbling that his party "should not be made a sacrificial lamb". It has also opposed Bhutto's demands for immunity for all elected governments from 1988 to 1999.

To counter Musharraf's attempts to court Bhutto, Shujaat launched his own efforts to win over Maulana Fazlur Rahman, a key component of MMA. There is already a visible split within MMA between Rahman's Jamiat-e-Ulema-Islam (JUI) and Qazi Hussain Ahmed's Jamaat-e-Islami. Rahman, who, for all his fire-brand rhetoric, is a practical politician at heart, has the most of all MMA leaders to lose from political chaos since he has the largest number of parliamentarians in the assemblies from MMA as well as control of NWFP and Balochistan governments. While Rahman has said publicly that he would not support Musharraf's re-election, there are continuing rumours of Shujaat offering him sweeteners including premiership to soften his stance. It is unlikely, however, that Musharraf would be willing to be seen to be cozying up to an Islamist 'hardliner' in the face of American pressure. And while Rahman served as chairman of the

elections, General Musharraf has made up his mind to stop down as army chief by the end of this year, which Bhutto could also take credit for as a result of her negotiations.

She has defended her deal with Musharraf as "not with an individual" but a part of her struggle for "peaceful transition to democracy". "This is critical for the other war—the war of moderation against extremism—to succeed," she wrote on the conservative US website *The Huffington Post*. "I had a choice. Engage in dialogue, or turn toward the streets. I knew that street protests against Musharraf dictatorship could lead to the deaths of hundreds. I thought about the choice

PRESSURE GROUPS: Chaudhry (top); resistance in frontier province before me very carefully. I chose dialogue; I chose negotiation."

The sticking points in the deal have to do with the future division of powers between Musharraf and the new prime minister, and with the fears of the President's current allies in parliament. Musharraf is unwilling to let go of presidential powers under Article 58(2)b to dissolve assemblies, which give him, in effect, a discretionary power over parliament. Bhutto has suffered twice as prime minister because of the same article and has demanded it be revoked as part of her bargain. It is unlikely that Musharraf